

Pine Savanna

PHOTO BY ALAN CRESSLER

IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Pine savannas, once dominated by longleaf pine, were historically central to Georgia's naval stores industry, producing turpentine, tar, and pitch. These open-canopied systems also supplied high-quality timber used for construction and shipbuilding.

The frequent fire regime naturally maintained their grassy understories and sparse tree spacing, supporting both timber production and incredible biodiversity. However, harvesting, fire suppression, and replanting with loblolly and slash pine altered their composition and reduced ecological function.

Despite this, pine savannas remain a key part of Georgia's forestry legacy. Today, restoration efforts using prescribed fire, BMPs, and selective thinning aim to revive their historic structure, enhancing both timber value and ecosystem health.



SOUTHERN HOGNOSE SNAKE
(*HETERODON SIMUS*)

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

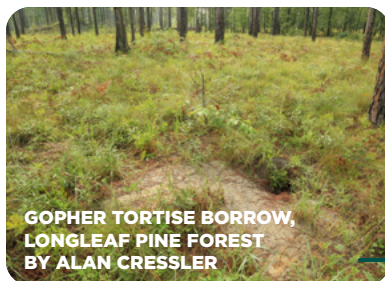
Pines are essential for these habitats, with longleaf pines being the staple. Typically, when there is a lot of sunlight on the ground due to lower tree density, these habitats exhibit lots of ground level vegetation. Wiregrass is dominant in Longleaf Pine-Wiregrass Savannas, but in other pine savanna systems numerous native bunch grasses are more common. Woody midstory and understory is limited due to the occurrence of periodic fire. Dry upland longleaf pine forests occur on level to rolling terrain throughout the Coastal Plain in a variety of settings: knolls, rolling hills, slopes above rivers, depressions within sandhills, and in the transition zones between sandhills and moister habitats such as pine flatwoods and seepage slopes.

SWAP Priority Habitat

Ecoregion(s)

Longleaf Pine-Wiregrass Savannas

Southeastern plains and Southeastern coastal plains



THREATS

- Habitat loss, degradation, and fragmentation, including clearing and conversion of habitat to agriculture, and residential and commercial development
- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Invasion of exotic pest plants and animals
- Indiscriminate herbicide use or mechanical vegetation treatments can reduce plant biodiversity and negatively impact ecosystem function.
- Overstocked stands can degrade habitat by creating closed canopy conditions and reducing sunlight on the ground.

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Use selective spot herbicide and mechanical treatments to control exotic pest plants.
- Clean vehicles, tractors, and equipment between sites if invasive species are present. If operations cannot be avoided in areas where invasive species are present, conduct operations in these areas last.
- Reduce invasion by woody vegetation utilizing prescribed fire on a 2-3-year rotation or with selective spot applications of herbicide if prescribed fire management is not an option.
- Maintain open canopy through selective thinning, if needed.
- Avoid offroad vehicle use. When roads or firebreaks are necessary, use Georgia's BMP manual to construct water bars, broad based dips, stream crossings and other practices to reduce erosion and runoff.
- Gopher tortoise burrows should be marked and avoided prior to logging operations. If Eastern indigo snakes occur on the site, avoid logging activities on these sandhills during their wintering season from November to March.
- If implementing prescribed burning, try to use existing boundary roads and natural features as fire breaks to minimize soil disturbance.

MORE INFORMATION

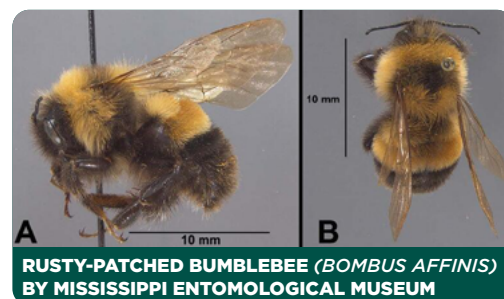
Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species via QR code below

Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard for more information and resources

